

| By Stephen David |

UNITING THE BUREAUCRACY WITH
THE LEADERSHIP WILL BE A TASK FOR
THE CHIEF MINISTER (CENTRE)



B K RAMESH

On September 29, a day after Dussehra, Karnataka Chief Minister B.S. Yeddyurappa and his team of ministers retired to a room in the serene environs of a 1,000-year-old Hindu mutt on the banks of the Kapila near Mysore, about 140 km from Bangalore. His Gujarat counterpart Narendra Modi arrived there a day earlier for a three-day brainstorming session—a pep-talk to Yeddyurappa and his team on the dos and don'ts for ministers and finer aspects of governance.

Fifteen months in the hot seat and the first ever BJP chief minister in the south is realising that power is a double-edged weapon. As for taking on the Opposition, the 67-year-old former rice mill clerk and RSS devotee need not worry: the JD(s) and the Congress are in a shambles, with each one of them trying clichéd and useless attempts to make their presence felt instead of bringing out white papers on the state's finances or methodically zeroing in on the black spots in governance. While the Congress headquarters has buried its head in the sand like an ostrich, the current state leadership is running around in circles like a headless chicken without making an impact. The JD(s), which continues to cut a huge swathe within the large Vokkaliga strongholds, is yet to break free from the perception of being a father and sons party; former prime minister H.D. Deve Gowda and sons H.D. Revanna and H.D. Kumaraswamy continue to hold sway.

A senior minister close to Yeddyurappa, one of the handful in his top team familiar with governance and skilled at extracting work from government servants, told INDIA TODAY

that the Government's biggest challenge now is to maximise output from officials. "Only 15 to 20 per cent of the officers deliver the goods. The rest are plodders," he said.

At a special week-long Assembly session on agriculture and rural development earlier this month, Yeddyurappa told the Legislative Council that the state Government is keen on tapping as much as Rs 2,000 crore from the funds available under the Centre's National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (NREGS). He blamed the officials for going slack on the programmes. The state had defaulted on tapping into the NREGS during the previous year as against Rs 2,201 crore sourced by Andhra Pradesh, Rs 1,170 crore by Rajasthan and Rs 5,069 crore by Madhya Pradesh. Karnataka, however, was able to make use of just Rs 428 crore. On more than one occasion, Yeddyurappa, who is known for losing his temper frequently, is said to have been enraged for not getting "enough cooperation" from his ministers and officials.

Meanwhile, Yeddyurappa has been travelling across the state. "My top leadership and I will go to the people and hear their grievances and look for practical solutions. I don't have to stay overnight in villagers' houses," he says, taking a dig at his predecessor Kumaraswamy who drew political mileage from overnight stays at villagers' houses. "He is open to ideas but is a taskmaster and expects all of us to keep pace with him," admits his Principal Secretary V.P. Baligar, adding, "He is a leader in a hurry." But the problem, as Yeddyurappa realises, is that not everybody wants to keep pace with him, not his ministers, his MLAs or officialdom.

“My top leadership and I will go to the people, hear their grievances and look for practical solutions.”

B. S. YEDDYURAPPA, CM, KARNATAKA